

No 3 Equal

PLATFORM

DIFFICULTY

DATE

Platform: CodeChef

DIV 3

Solved: June 3, 2026

Problem

Make sure no three consecutive characters are equal.

Algorithm

Traverse string.

Find block length.

Add: $\text{ans} += \text{len} / 3$;

Example

aaaaaa
length = 6
 $6/3 = 2$
Answer = 2

Key Observation

For a block:

aaaaaa

Length = 6

Every 3 equal letters require one modification.

Therefore:

$$\text{changes} = \lfloor \frac{\text{len}}{3} \rfloor$$

Formula

For every maximal block:

$$\text{ans} + = \text{len}/3$$

TC & SC

Time Complexity : $O(N)$

Space Complexity : $O(1)$

←

—

Scored

🔍

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StatementSubmissionsClarifications

No 3 Equal

You have a string S of length N consisting of lower case English characters.

You say that a string is good if there is **no** index i such that $1 \leq i \leq N - 2$ and $S_i = S_{i+1} = S_{i+2}$.

Find the minimum number of edits you need to make to the string to make it good. Each edit is changing one character to any other lower case English character.

Input Format

- The first line of input will contain a single integer T , denoting the number of test cases.
- Each test case consists of multiple lines of input.
 - The first line contains an integer N .
 - The second line contains a string S .

Output Format

For each test case, output the minimum edits.

Constraints

- $1 \leq T \leq 100$
- $1 \leq N \leq 100$
- $|S| = N$
- S contains lowercase English Characters.

Sample 1:

Input	Output
3	2
6	0
aaaaaa	1
4	
aabc	
5	
baaac	

Java

```
1 import java.util.*;
2 import java.lang.*;
3 import java.io.*;
4
5 class Codechef
6 {
7     public static void main (String[] args) throws java.lang.Exception
8     {
9         // your code goes here
10        Scanner sc = new Scanner(System.in);
11
12        int T = sc.nextInt();
13
14        while (T-- > 0) {
15            int N = sc.nextInt();
16            String s = sc.next();
17
18            int ans = 0;
19            int i = 0;
20
21            while (i < N) {
22                int j = i;
23
24                while (j < N && s.charAt(j) == s.charAt(i)) {
25                    j++;
26                }
27
28                int len = j - i;
29                ans += len / 3;
30
31                i = j;
32            }
33
34            System.out.println(ans);
35        }
36    }
37
38    sc.close();
39
40 }
```

Test against Custom Input

✓ Correct Answer

Submission ID: 1285426256

Sub-Task	Task #	Result (time)
1	0	Correct (0.07)

Visualize Code

RunSubmit